Ask it well

Lesson 6 notes. Fill in the blanks as we go.

The assistant usually doesn't ask what you mean. It _____.

Weak and strong

Weak	Strong
tell me about space	How do astronauts sleep on the International Space Station?
climate	How does warming ocean water hurt coral reefs?
help with my report	I'm writing a report on the Dust Bowl. What caused it, and how did it change farming?
who is best president	Which U.S. presidents do historians rank highest, and why do they disagree?

The four parts

Part	It means	Example
_____	Exactly what it's about	"Gray wolves", not "animals"
_____	What you want to know	"What do they eat in winter?"
_____	Why you're asking	"For a report"
_____	What you want back	"Three causes"

You don't need all four, but you need more than _____.

Habits of good askers

- Use the words a _____ would use. "Coral bleaching" finds more than "why reefs look dead".
- Ask _____ thing at a time, then follow up.
- If the first answer misses, change the prompt. A prompt is a _____.
- Leave out _____ details, yours and anyone else's.

> **Finding too few books?** Go one step broader for books, and narrower for the answer.

Our prompt ladder

Our topic: _____ _____

Rung	Our prompt	What the overview gave us	Best book	What we changed next
1. One word				
2. A specific question				
3. A purpose or limits				

Shelf check. One claim from our best answer: _____ _____ Did the book back it up? _____

Take it with you

- **Stop making it guess.** Say what you actually want to know.
- **Specific beats long.** Extra words aren't the point.
- **A prompt is a draft.** Change it when it isn't working.
- **Strong doesn't mean true.** A sharper question can still get an invented name or date.
- A book named in the overview may not be in our library. Only **Books in our library** are real Records.

Check yourself

1. Rewrite "dogs" as a strong prompt about something you actually want to know.
2. Which is stronger, and why? (a) "tell me everything about Rome" (b) "Why did people in ancient Rome build aqueducts?"
3. True or false, and explain: "If I write a great prompt, I don't need to check the answer."